

minister's popularity should remain high in the seventh year of his rule (he came to power in 2001 and won the 2002 polls) is itself an unprecedented phenomenon. Says political analyst Arvind Bosamia, "In Gujarat, Hindutva remains a strong issue. His public image remains largely infallible despite the attacks he is facing. He is to Gujarat what Indira Gandhi was to India in the late 1960s and early '70s."

This is not to suggest that Modi is immune to the caste card challenge. It has already forced him to make Hindutva paramount in his strategy for the next polls in December while originally, according to his aides, his main plan was to highlight development that the state has made under his leadership. The Congress virtually had a strategy ready to portray Modi's claims on development as a sham, encourage anti-incumbency by playing up small but moving local issues and portray the chief minister's image of a tough man as that of an arrogant man. This strategy also had the support of powerful anti-Modi leaders in BJP close to Keshubhai Patel, like Vallabh Kathiria, Gordhan Jhadaphia and Dhirubhai Gajera. It was this commonality that saw Patel and BJP dissidents joining hands with caste mates of the Congress to organise a community meet in Surat to honour Patel leaders.

That the meet was inaugurated by national VIP General Secretary Pravin Togadia and a Patel, was only indicative of the caste-based divisions within the Sangh Parivar in the just-concluded Guru Golwalkar birth centenary year in which the Sangh worked for Hindu unity throughout the year. Togadia's presence at the function, with Patel leaders of the

Congress, and his call to the Patels to unite caused great consternation within the VHP, which has always preached against casteism.

The Congress, no less than the BJP dissidents, has not been allowing a single opportunity to go waste while playing the caste card. Recently, it played up the rape and murder of a Koli girl near Junagadh. Koli leaders of both the

REBIRTH: Sonia addressed massive gatherings throughout the state

anti-Modi-Koli alliance. Modi's recent compromise with the state government employees, who were threatening to go on strike on their demands and his announcement that he will remove octroi from seven municipal corporations in the state by Diwali, has removed two big obstacles from his poll path.

Congress, which was in intensive care for the last several years, is showing signs of life. This is largely due to the combined efforts of its top leaders

from Ahmed Patel to Bharatsinh Solanki and Shankarsinh Vaghela. The party is particularly hopeful of putting up a good show in rural areas where factors such as anti-incumbency are but natural against a government sitting in power for nearly seven years. The fresh enthusiasm in the Congress is also evident from the business-like manner in which its state headquarters in Ahmedabad has begun to function. Congress is banking on the fact that at the height of the Hindutva movement, BJP under Modi had won 127 seats.

If the Congress finds the going tough, it will only be because of the charges of Muslim-appeasement that are gaining momentum in the state that the BJP calls "showcase". Modi is already devising a strategy to sell the Congress as a second version of the Muslims League, capitalising on the fact that the Congress stance on Muslim de-

mands such as reservation in jobs and bank loans is very close to the stance of Jinnah's Muslim League before the Partition. The Hindutva trigger in Gujarat was clearly evident in the aftermath of the Sohrabuddin fake encounter issue. And if there is one leader to who can turn the Congress' Muslim-appeasement to his own advantage, it is undoubtedly Narendra Damodar Modi.



Sonia has been able to revive the party but charges of Muslim appeasement still stick.

Congress and the BJP came on one platform to highlight the incident (in which the perpetrator, a Dalit ruffian, is still at large) and sell the case as injustice to the Koli community. Demonstrations against the Government were organised on the issue in important towns of the state. But in the final run, Modi was able to de-fang some powerful Koli leaders including the state Fisheries Minister Purshottam Solanki from the